INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #6 · PARENTING

"I'm a failure as a parent."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Parenting is the one job where we are graded daily and never fully trained. Comparison with other parents, a child's struggles, our own childhood wounds, and criticism from relatives or church can leave us convinced that we are failing. Perfectionism tells us that any mistake is proof.

What Scripture teaches

God describes Himself as a Father who understands our limits: "As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him." He "tends His flock like a shepherd; He gathers the lambs in His arms and carries them close to His heart. He gently leads the nursing ewes." Even the best human parent needs this gentle leading. Jeremiah says of God, "His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!" Parenting well is not parenting perfectly. It is loving, repairing, and keeping on, and God supplies what we lack.

> *"He tends His flock like a shepherd; He gathers the lambs in His arms and carries them close to His heart. He gently leads the nursing ewes"* (Isaiah 40:11).

Also see

> "As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him" (Psalm 103:13).

> "Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!" (Lamentations 3:22–23).

> "Being confident of this, that He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus" (Philippians 1:6).

> "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me" (2 Corinthians 12:9).

Common self-statements

- Good parents do not make these mistakes.
- Everyone else is doing better than I am.
- I yelled again, so I am a terrible parent.
- My child deserves better.
- I do not know what I am doing.
- I am failing them.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling myself "a failure" instead of describing a mistake.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either perfect or failing.
- Social comparison: Measuring myself against other parents' best moments.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking the love and care I give.

Challenging questions

- What exactly have I done that I call failure, and what is the evidence on the other side?

- What would I say to a friend who was parenting as I am?
- What does my child need most, perfection or presence and repair?
- How does God treat parents who are tired and unsure?
- Where do I need to apologize, and where do I need to forgive myself?
- What is one small thing I can do well this week?

Truth summary

> I am not a perfect parent, and I do not need to be. My child needs a loving parent who repairs mistakes, not a flawless one. God leads gently those who care for little ones, and His mercies are new every morning.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Parenting
- Children
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Guilt/Shame
- Mercy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Parenting
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm a failure as a parent"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm a failure as a parent." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I call failure?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend?
- ☐ What does my child need?
- ☐ What do I need to repair?
- ☐ What do I do well?
- ☐ Who can support me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Good parenting is not perfect parenting.
- ☐ God gently leads parents.
- ☐ His mercies are new every morning.
- ☐ I can apologize and repair.
- ☐ My love matters to my child.
- ☐ God will finish what He began.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Isaiah 40:11
  "He tends His flock like a shepherd; He gathers the lambs in His arms and carries them close to His heart. He gently leads the nursing ewes."
- ☐ Psalm 103:13
  "As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him."
- ☐ Lamentations 3:22–23
  "Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Repair and love: Each week, write one mistake you repaired or one loving thing you did.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Isaiah 40:11 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God gently leads me as I care for my child.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Parenting" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Separate mistakes from identity. Write what happened as facts, without the word "failure."
- [ ] Apologize if needed. Tell your child a simple, sincere sorry.
- [ ] List what you do well. Write ten ways you care for your child.
- [ ] Ask for support. Talk with a trusted parent, pastor, or counselor.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm a failure as a parent": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A repair made
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm a failure as a parent.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I feel like I am failing. Lead me gently as You lead those with young. Forgive my mistakes, help me repair them, and fill in what I lack. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #7 · PARENTING

“If my child struggles, it's my fault.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Parents often feel responsible for everything that happens to their children. When a child struggles with anxiety, school, friends, behavior, or faith, we search our own parenting for the cause. Well-meaning advice and a misreading of verses about training children can add to the weight.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says, “A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son.” “Each of us will give an account of himself to God.” Children are individuals with their own will, temperament, and choices. Proverbs says, “Train up a child in the way he should go, and when he is old he will not depart from it.” That is a general principle of wise living, not a guarantee, and not a measure of a parent’s worth. The father in Jesus’ story of the prodigal son did nothing wrong, and yet his son left. When his son came back, “his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him.”

> *“The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him”* (Ezekiel 18:20).

Also see

> “So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God” (Romans 14:12).

> “Train up a child in the way he should go, and when he is old he will not depart from it” (Proverbs 22:6).

> “So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him” (Luke 15:20).

> “As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him” (Psalm 103:13).

Common self-statements

- I must have caused this.
- If I had been a better parent, they would not struggle.
- It is all because of what I did.
- I should have seen this coming.
- Other parents’ kids are fine.
- It is my job to fix everything.

Common logical errors

- Personalization: Taking responsibility for things beyond my control.
- Hindsight bias: Judging past choices by what I know now.
- Mind reading: Assuming my child blames me.
- Magical thinking: Believing good parenting guarantees a good outcome.

Challenging questions

- What factors beyond me contribute, such as temperament, friends, biology, or choices?
- Has my child made decisions that are their own?
- What real mistakes, if any, can I own without taking all the blame?
- What does the father in the prodigal son story teach me?
- What does my child need from me now?
- What can I trust God with?

Truth summary

> I influence my children, but I do not control them. Some of what they face is not my fault, and some may be mine to own and repair. I can love them, take responsibility for what is mine, and trust God with the rest.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Parenting
- Children
- Guilt/Shame
- Trust
- Adolescent Guidance

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Parenting
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Good Good Father — Chris Tomlin
God's fatherly love is deeper than human approval or achievement.

Our God — Chris Tomlin
God's greatness challenges helplessness before evil or hardship.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If my child struggles, it's my fault"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If my child struggles, it's my fault." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What factors beyond me are involved?
- ☐ What is mine to own?
- ☐ What can I release?
- ☐ What does my child need now?
- ☐ What can I apologize for?
- ☐ How can I pray?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My child is responsible for their own choices.
- ☐ I am not the cause of everything.
- ☐ I can own real mistakes and repair them.
- ☐ A loving father runs to meet a returning child.
- ☐ God cares for my child more than I do.
- ☐ I can trust God with what I cannot control.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Ezekiel 18:20**
  "The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him."
- ☐ **Luke 15:20**
  "So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him."
- ☐ **Romans 14:12**
  "So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God."

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Mine and not mine: Each week, write one thing that is mine to do and one thing you will release to God.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 14:12 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Each person answers to God, so I do not carry what is not mine.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Parenting" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Make two columns. List what is yours to own and what is not.
- ☐ Own what is true. If there is a real mistake, apologize without excuses or self-punishment.
- ☐ Be present. Spend one-on-one time with your child without fixing.
- ☐ Pray for your child. Pray by name, entrusting them to God each day.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If my child struggles, it's my fault": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Released to God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If my child struggles, it's my fault.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I carry my child's struggles as my own guilt. Show me what is mine to own and what is not. Help me love them well and trust them to You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #8 · PARENTING

“I have ruined my children.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Looking back on yelling, divorce, absence, addiction, neglect, or hard years, some parents decide the damage is permanent. Guilt can be especially heavy when a child is hurting now and we can see the connection. Shame then says, “It is too late and they are broken because of me.”

What Scripture teaches

God speaks of restoration: “I will repay you for the years eaten by locusts.” The Lord says, “Keep your voice from weeping and your eyes from tears, for the reward for your work will come… So there is hope for your future, declares the LORD, and your children will return.” Paul writes that “if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation,” and Joseph told his brothers, “what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good.” This is not a denial of real harm. It is a promise that God can redeem what we cannot, and that repentance, repair, and prayer can change a story that is not finished.

> *“I will repay you for the years eaten by locusts— the swarming locust, the young locust, the destroying locust, and the devouring locust— My great army that I sent against you”* (Joel 2:25).

Also see

> “This is what the LORD says: ‘Keep your voice from weeping and your eyes from tears, for the reward for your work will come, declares the LORD. Then your children will return from the land of the enemy. So there is hope for your future, declares the LORD, and your children will return to their own land.’” (Jeremiah 31:16–17).

> “As for you, what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good, in order to accomplish a day like this—to preserve the lives of many people” (Genesis 50:20).

> “‘Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.’” (Isaiah 43:18–19).

> “And we know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose” (Romans 8:28).

Common self-statements

- The damage is permanent.
- They will never forgive me.
- I cannot undo what I did.
- My children are hurt because of me.
- It is too late to make it right.
- I destroyed their childhood.

Common logical errors

- Catastrophizing: Treating real harm as irreversible ruin.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that my children will never recover.

- Labeling: Calling myself a ruiner.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling terrible and concluding the damage is total.

Challenging questions

- What specifically do I believe I did, and what is the actual impact on each child?
- Have I acknowledged it to my children, and how did they respond?
- What strengths and good memories do my children also have?
- What does God say about restoring lost years?
- What can I do now to repair, listen, and love?
- What is not in my control?

Truth summary

> I have made real mistakes, and some have hurt my children. But I have not ruined them beyond God's ability to restore. I can repent, repair what I can, listen, and pray, trusting God to redeem what I cannot.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Parenting
- Forgiveness
- Repent
- Confession
- Mercy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Parenting
- Trouble/Hardship

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I have ruined my children"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have ruined my children." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly do I regret?
- ☐ What is the impact on each child?
- ☐ Have I apologized?
- ☐ What strengths do my children have?
- ☐ What can I repair now?
- ☐ What can I trust to God?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God can restore the years the locusts have eaten.
- ☐ There is hope for my future and my children's.
- ☐ Repentance and repair matter.
- ☐ God can turn evil to good.
- ☐ I am a new creation in Christ.
- ☐ The story is not finished.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Joel 2:25

  "I will repay you for the years eaten by locusts— the swarming locust, the young locust, the destroying locust, and the devouring locust— My great army that I sent against you."

- ☐ Jeremiah 31:16–17

  "This is what the LORD says: 'Keep your voice from weeping and your eyes from tears, for the reward for your work will come, declares the LORD. Then your children will return from the land of the enemy. So there is hope for your future, declares the LORD, and your children will return to their own land.'"

- ☐ Genesis 50:20

  "As for you, what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good, in order to accomplish a day like this—to preserve the lives of many people."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] One repair: Each week, record one step of repair, such as an apology, a listening conversation, or a prayer.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Joel 2:25 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God can restore the years that were lost.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Repent" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Face the facts. Write what happened without exaggerating or minimizing.
- [ ] Apologize without excuses. Tell each child what you are sorry for, then listen.
- [ ] Seek help. Consider family counseling or a pastor if needed.
- [ ] Pray Joel 2:25. Ask God to restore what was lost.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have ruined my children": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step of repair
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have ruined my children.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I carry deep regret over how I have hurt my children. Forgive me, give me courage to repair what I can, and redeem what I cannot. Restore the years that were lost. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #9 · PARENTING

“I'm turning into my own parents.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Many of us hear our parent’s words come out of our own mouths and feel a chill. If we grew up with anger, coldness, addiction, or control, we may fear that we are destined to repeat it. The fear can be so strong that it makes us anxious, hypervigilant, or afraid to be close to our children.

What Scripture teaches

Paul says, “Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” God promises, “I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you; I will remove your heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh.” The fruit of the Spirit is “love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control.” Paul also says, “I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength.” Patterns can pass down, but they are not destiny. Noticing the pattern is the first step in breaking it.

> *“Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!”* (2 Corinthians 5:17).

Also see

> “I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you; I will remove your heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh” (Ezekiel 36:26).

> “But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. Against such things there is no law” (Galatians 5:22–23).

> “I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength” (Philippians 4:13).

> “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God” (Romans 12:2).

Common self-statements

- I am becoming exactly what I swore I would not.
- It is in my blood.
- I cannot help it.
- My children will end up like me.
- I never had a good model.
- I will repeat the same cycle.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting that I will repeat the past.
- Labeling: Calling myself “just like them.”
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either totally different or the same.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling afraid and concluding that it is inevitable.

Challenging questions

- In what specific ways do I notice I am like my parent, and in what ways am I different?

- What good qualities did I also receive from them?
- What triggers my reactions, and what can I do differently in that moment?
- What does Scripture say about a new heart?
- Who can help me learn new ways to parent?
- What small change can I make today?

Truth summary

> I am not doomed to repeat my parents' patterns. In Christ I am a new creation, and God gives me a new heart and His Spirit. I can notice old reactions, pause, repair, and practice new ones.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Parenting
- Anger
- Born Again
- Sinful Nature
- Holy Spirit

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Parenting
- Anger

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Chain Breaker — Zach Williams
Christ offers rescue and freedom to people who feel trapped by their past.

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Salvation and freedom come through grace rather than earning acceptance.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm turning into my own parents"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm turning into my own parents." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ How am I like my parent?
- ☐ How am I different?
- ☐ What triggers me?
- ☐ What will I do in the moment?
- ☐ Who can help me learn?
- ☐ What is one change today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am a new creation in Christ.
- ☐ God gives me a new heart.
- ☐ The Spirit produces patience and gentleness in me.
- ☐ Patterns can be broken.
- ☐ Noticing is the first step.
- ☐ I can learn new ways.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 2 Corinthians 5:17
  "Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!"
- ☐ Ezekiel 36:26
  "I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you; I will remove your heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh."
- ☐ Galatians 5:22–23
  "But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. Against such things there is no law."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Old pattern, new response: Each week, write one moment you noticed an old reaction and how you responded differently or repaired.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, 2 Corinthians 5:17 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am a new creation in Christ, not a copy of my parents.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Anger" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ List differences. Write ways your parenting is already different from theirs.
- ☐ Plan a pause. Decide on a phrase or action to use when you are triggered.
- ☐ Learn a skill. Read a book, take a class, or see a counselor on parenting.
- ☐ Repair quickly. When you slip, apologize and try again.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm turning into my own parents": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A new response
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm turning into my own parents.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I fear repeating what I grew up with. Make me new. Give me a heart that is gentle and patient, and teach me ways of loving my children that I never saw. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #10 · PARENTING

“It's too late to be a good parent to my kids.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Parents of teenagers and adult children often feel the window has closed. Years of absence, anger, addiction, or distraction cannot be taken back. Our children may be distant or grown, and we conclude that nothing we do now will matter.

What Scripture teaches

Jeremiah records God’s word: “There is hope for your future, declares the LORD, and your children will return to their own land.” The Lord “will turn the hearts of the fathers to their children, and the hearts of the children to their fathers.” Peter says that the Lord “is patient with you.” The father of the prodigal son was waiting, and when the son was still far away, “his father saw him and was filled with compassion.” Late is not too late with God. Relationship can grow at any age, through humility, consistency, and time.

> *“So there is hope for your future, declares the LORD, and your children will return to their own land”* (Jeremiah 31:17).

Also see

> “And he will turn the hearts of the fathers to their children, and the hearts of the children to their fathers. Otherwise, I will come and strike the land with a curse” (Malachi 4:6).

> “So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him” (Luke 15:20).

> “The Lord is not slow in keeping His promise as some understand slowness, but is patient with you, not wanting anyone to perish but everyone to come to repentance” (2 Peter 3:9).

> “Even when I am old and gray, do not forsake me, O God, until I proclaim Your power to the next generation, Your might to all who are to come” (Psalm 71:18).

Common self-statements

- They are grown and the damage is done.
- They do not need me now.
- I missed my chance.
- Nothing I say will matter.
- They will never want a relationship with me.
- I should have changed years ago.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that relationship is either perfect or over.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that my children will not respond.
- Catastrophizing: Treating a late start as total loss.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking small openings that already exist.

Challenging questions

- What would a good next step toward my child look like, however small?
- What do my children actually need from me now, such as an apology, a listener, or a grandparent?
- Who in Scripture or in my experience reconciled late in life?
- What is the cost of giving up?
- What does God say about turning hearts?
- What would I want to have tried if I had ten more years?

Truth summary

> It is not too late. God turns hearts and restores relationships in His time. I can offer humility, consistency, and love without demanding a particular response, and I can pray for what I cannot control.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Parenting
- Children
- Hopeless
- Repent
- Forgiveness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Parenting
- Depression

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Good Good Father — Chris Tomlin
God's fatherly love is deeper than human approval or achievement.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "It's too late to be a good parent to my kids"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"It's too late to be a good parent to my kids." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What small step can I take?
- ☐ What do my children need now?
- ☐ What apology is owed?
- ☐ What would I try with ten more years?
- ☐ How can I be consistent?
- ☐ How can I pray?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ There is hope for my future.
- ☐ God turns the hearts of parents and children.
- ☐ It is never too late to repent and begin.
- ☐ My children can still receive love.
- ☐ Small steps matter.
- ☐ God is patient with me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Jeremiah 31:17
  "So there is hope for your future, declares the LORD, and your children will return to their own land."
- ☐ Malachi 4:6
  "And he will turn the hearts of the fathers to their children, and the hearts of the children to their fathers. Otherwise, I will come and strike the land with a curse."
- ☐ Luke 15:20
  "So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] A step toward: Each week, write one small step you took to connect with your child.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Jeremiah 31:17 becomes: "Sarah can write: "There is hope for my future, and my children can still be reached.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Hopeless" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Choose a small step. Send a short, kind message with no expectations.
- [ ] Write an honest apology. Own your part without excuses and without asking for anything in return.
- [ ] Be consistent. Show up in small, reliable ways over time.
- [ ] Pray daily for your child. Pray by name every day.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "It's too late to be a good parent to my kids": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step toward
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My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

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My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~It's too late to be a good parent to my kids.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I wish I could go back. Thank You that it is not too late with You. Turn hearts, heal what I broke, and show me one small step toward my child today. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.